ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

AI Tools for Studying: Use Them Without Cheating Yourself

Where AI genuinely helps learning, and where it quietly damages your degree

DIGITAL SKILLS

Digital Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

AI tools are useful tutors and dangerous shortcuts. This pack explains what they do well, where they confidently produce wrong answers, how to write prompts that produce checkable output, and how to stay within your department's integrity rules.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Use AI for explanation, practice and feedback rather than submission.
- Write prompts that specify context, level and output format.
- Verify AI output against reliable sources and detect fabricated references.
- Apply your department's rules on disclosure and permitted use.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What AI is good at

Treat AI as an explainer and practice partner, not an author.

- Re-explaining a concept at a simpler level until you understand it.
- Generating practice questions on a topic you specify.
- Critiquing your own draft for structure and clarity.
- Producing examples and analogies you then verify.
- Summarising a document you already have, as a first pass only.
- Translating and checking grammar in your own writing.

What it gets wrong

Language models produce plausible text, not verified truth.

- Fabricated references, statistics and quotations.
- Confident errors in calculations and niche local detail.
- Outdated information on current events, policies and prices.
- Bias and oversimplification on contested topics.
- Generic writing that sounds like nobody in particular.
- Hidden errors when you lack the knowledge to check the answer.

> **The verification rule**
> If you cannot check a claim yourself, do not submit it. A citation you have not opened is not a source.

Prompting and integrity

Better prompts produce more checkable answers.

- State your level, the course, the length and the required format.
- Ask for step-by-step explanation rather than the final answer.
- Request sources, then verify each one independently.
- Ask it to identify weaknesses in your argument, not to write the argument.
- Disclose AI assistance where your department requires it.
- Never use AI where it is prohibited; an acknowledgement does not make a prohibited act allowed.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name three legitimate study uses of AI.

Answer: Explaining a concept, generating practice questions and giving feedback on your draft.

2. Why are AI-generated references risky?

Answer: Models can fabricate plausible-looking citations that do not exist or do not say what is claimed.

3. Write a useful prompt for studying a topic.

Answer: For example: 'Explain photosynthesis to a 100-level biology student in 250 words with one worked example, then give me five practice questions with answers.'

4. What should you do if your department prohibits AI use?

Answer: Do not use it for that assessment; follow the policy even if you believe disclosure would be honest.

5. How can AI damage your learning?

Answer: By replacing the retrieval and reasoning practice that builds durable knowledge, leaving you unable to perform in examinations.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Read your department's policy on AI use.
- [ ] Write three prompts that request explanation, not answers.
- [ ] Verify five AI-generated facts against a textbook or official site.
- [ ] Check every cited source by opening it.
- [ ] Use AI to critique one of your own drafts.
- [ ] Complete one assignment with no AI assistance to test your own ability.
- [ ] Record when and how you used AI for transparency.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: